

team in any way possible. Even Sushila [Chanu] called me and said, 'Savi, you have to motivate the group and speak to them'."

To ease the mental burden, Hockey India enlisted Bengaluru-based Behavioural Foresight, a performance science group that has worked with Indian Premier League side Rajasthan Royals and shuttler H.S. Prannoy. "Two to three times a week, they are taking classes as a group and individually also. This is important because when you are young, you tend to focus and think about a lot of things. They are helping them master the art of focusing on one or two things at a time. And the results are evident, I can see it on the pitch," Harendra said.

Even without Savita, sidelined with a foot injury, there is optimism. "Before the Tokyo Olympics, we weren't in the Pro League either. We had unity, and that's why we did well," Savita reflected.

Player to watch out for DEEPIKA

The 21-year-old forward from Haryana will be India's chief attacking threat. Six of her seven Pro League goals came from penalty corners, but Deepika underlined her versatility by winning FIH's Poligras Magic Skill Award for a solo effort against the Netherlands in the 2024-25 FIH Pro League. With 31 goals in 64 appearances for India, she has built an enviable record against Asian rivals, scoring 12 times in 17 matches against Thailand, China, and Japan.

Fixing the leak with experience

India's defence has been porous. Across 16 Pro League matches, it conceded more than 100 penalty corners, including 17 in a single game against Belgium. Of the 43 goals allowed, 23 came from penalty corners. Much of the blame has fallen on an inexperienced backline.

"We are working on the regaining part of the game. Experience is needed, especially while slowing down counter-attacks from European sides, which can be very quick. We are working on that now with the youngsters," said Udit, who

Rankings

Country	World	Asia
China	4	1
India	9	2
Japan	12	3
South Korea	16	4
Malaysia	25	5
Thailand	30	6
Singapore	31	7
Chinese Taipei	40	10

managed only four League matches due to fitness issues.

Jyoti, a forward-turned-defender, was thrust into greater responsibility in the absence of seniors like Sushila, Udit, and Nikki Pradhan. "Many of us were new. Experienced players know what needs to be done in every situation, but one mistake from an inexperienced defender can result in a goal," the 25-year-old admitted.

Harendra explained that young defenders, eager to win the ball, often dived in and gave away soft penalty corners. "In hockey and even in football, the central defender acts like the pivot.

If they know their job, 50 per cent of your defence is sorted. My three centre defenders were out for the majority of the Pro League. The adjustments included pulling midfielders like Manisha and Vaishnavi [Phalke] back into defence, and giving more responsibility to Jyoti. One player cannot last the whole season as the main centre defender."

The solution, he said, lies in structure: "The diamond formation helps protect the centre. There should be at least four players present to prevent counterattacks. That's something we are working on."

With Udit and Nikki back in the squad, Harendra expects a



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